

coupons and discounts were the primary reason they became fans of a brand on Facebook.

It isn't just moms jumping on the Internet bandwagon either. The research group eMarketer estimated that in 2009 users in the forty-five to sixty-three age group made up 28.8 percent of the total online population, to the tune of 57.4 million consumers. While individuals over sixty-five still make up less than 10 percent of the active Internet universe, their numbers are also on the rise.

The Social Networks of Facebook and Twitter have become an attractive venue for retailers to influence consumers. Successful retailers today know the importance of responding to their customers, and what better way than to go where consumers are in the online communities. In April 2011, Facebook joined the coupon market, offering users in five US cities coupons for everything from wine tastings to concert tickets. The special "Deals" coupons were offered directly through the Facebook service at a limited discount price. A week before that, Google Inc. had begun marketing a daily deal service dubbed "Offers" to users in Portland, Oregon.

With these new services, Facebook and Google jumped on the bandwagon of the concept of "daily deals" that was pioneered by Groupon. Somewhat like an online version of the coupons you get in the mail from a local merchant or a Yellow Page ad, Groupon took the coupon discount and added a novelty of requiring a certain amount of consumers to purchase the discount within a set time frame, before it became valid. Christopher Steiner, in an August 2010 *Forbes* article, described it as "a cents-off